



DELHI | Wargame Season

Over 50,000 Pakistani troops, tanks and fighter aircraft are engaged in joint army-air force exercises, the country's largest wargames in over two decades. Also deployed were new acquisitions like the Swedish Erieye airborne early warning radars, Ukrainian IL-78 tankers and drones along with all of the post-9/11 military aid from the US, including Cobra gunships, F-16 fighter jets and its newly upgraded fleet of main battle tanks. The Pakistan army's Azm-e-Nau (new resolve) and the air force's High Mark 2010 six-week exercise in Punjab and Sindh may be a response to the Indian army's ongoing Yodha Shakti exercise in Rajasthan, but the message runs far deeper. Two of the Pakistan army's corps are deployed in counter insurgency (CI) operations against the Taliban in South Waziristan along the Afghan border. Pakistani strategists are not too pleased about redeploying nearly one-fifth of their army in CI ops, leaving their eastern borders with India vulnerable. "The exercises are aimed at dispelling any notion that we have a conventional edge over the Pakistan army because of their CI deployments in the west," says Lt-General H.S. Panag (retd). Pakistani officials say the exercises will 'focus on a conventional war on its eastern borders' and blunt the Indian army's new 'Cold Start' offensive doctrine, which calls for instant strikes followed by mobilisation.

PAKISTAN'S T-80 TANKS, ANTI-AIRCRAFT GUNS AND COBRA HELICOPTER GUNSHIPS DURING THE EXERCISE

by Sandeep Unnithan

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days is how long 25,000 troops of the Mathura-based 1 Corps will participate in the Yodha Shakti exercise to validate the army's new Cold Start doctrine.